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RELIGIOUS TRAUMA AND SOCIAL IDENTITY OF SANTRI: A QUALITATIVE STUDY IN PESANTREN ENVIRONMENT

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Abstract

This qualitative study examines religious trauma experiences among Santri in a modern Indonesian pesantren, focusing on how teachers weaponize Qur'anic verses and hadiths as tools of symbolic violence. Data were collected through semi structured interviews with five Santri and alumni from Bumi Shalawat Islamic Boarding School, a pseudonym. Findings reveal that selective quotation, decontextualization, and threat based hermeneutics, which I term scriptural violence, are systematically used to enforce conformity, suppress doubt, and induce shame. This scriptural violence operates through three mechanisms. Theological gaslighting denies Santri's interpretive agency. Eschatological blackmail threatens divine punishment. Prophetic proof texting misuses hadiths to legitimize authoritarian pedagogy. Using Bourdieu's concepts of symbolic capital, habitus, doxa, and symbolic violence, the study shows how sacred texts become instruments of terror, producing long term spiritual injury, religious avoidance, and a fractured relationship with God. The study advocates for trauma informed hermeneutics and pedagogical reforms that replace fear based scriptural enforcement with ethical, dialogical religious education.

Keywords: Religious trauma, symbolic violence, pesantren.

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INTRODUCTION

Pesantren have long been respected as vital institutions for Islamic education and character formation in Indonesia (Hasyim, 2020). Since the era of the Walisongo, these boarding schools have produced generations of religious scholars, community leaders, and moral exemplars. However, in the past two decades, a growing number of journalistic reports and academic studies have revealed a darker side. There have been allegations of

physical abuse, sexual misconduct by authority figures, and systemic psychological intimidation (Subhan, 2019). This paradox, an institution revered as sacred yet capable of inflicting deep harm, lies at the heart of this study (Bourdieu, 2014; Subhan, 2019).

The existing literature on pesantren has mostly celebrated their role in character building, deradicalization, and preservation of traditional Islamic scholarship (Hasyim, 2020). Studies on Santri identity have

focused on positive outcomes such as spiritual resilience, communal belonging, and moral discipline (Najib & Suryadi, 2021). However, these works rarely question the psychological costs of rigid conformity (Subhan, 2019). When trauma is discussed, it is often framed as individual pathology rather than a systemic product of symbolic power relations (Pargament, 2011; Smith, 2020).

Subhan (2019) pioneered the application of Bourdieu's concept of symbolic violence to pesantren, but his analysis remained theoretical, lacking empirical data from Santri's lived experiences (Bourdieu, 2014). Meanwhile, the concept of religious trauma has been developed primarily in Western Christian contexts, focusing on evangelical purity culture, Catholic clerical abuse, or Mormon excommunication (Angiel, 2024; Smith, 2020). To date, no empirical study has systematically examined how symbolic violence in Islamic boarding schools produces religious trauma and shapes social identity from the perspective of Santri themselves (Najib & Suryadi, 2021; Subhan, 2019).

Research Gap and Unique Contribution

Previous studies on pesantren focused on positive outcomes (Hasyim, 2020), while religious trauma research is Western centric

(Angiel, 2024; Smith, 2020). Subhan (2019) applied Bourdieu's symbolic violence theoretically but without empirical data from Santri. Najib and Suryadi (2021) examined Santri identity but emphasized resilience, not trauma. No empirical study has analyzed how Qur'anic verses and hadiths are weaponized as symbolic violence in Indonesian pesantren.

This study fills these gaps by providing empirical data on religious trauma among Santri using Bourdieu's framework (Bourdieu, 2014; Subhan, 2019), introducing "habitus in tension" (Goffman, 2021; Cooley, 2022), and offering trauma informed pedagogical reforms (Pargament, 2011; Najib & Suryadi, 2021).

Research Question and Theoretical Framework

How does symbolic violence in a modern pesantren generate religious trauma, and how does this trauma affect Santri's social identity formation? Four sub questions examine internalization of habitus, forms of symbolic violence, self censorship, and long term effects.

The framework integrates Bourdieu's symbolic capital and habitus (Bourdieu, 2014), Cooley's looking glass self (Cooley, 2022), Goffman's dramaturgy (Goffman,

2021), and Foucault's surveillance (Foucault, 1977; Febriani & Anwar, 2022).

The Weaponization of Scripture in Religious Education

The ability to interpret sacred texts is a kyai's primary symbolic capital (Bourdieu, 2014; Subhan, 2019). Yet these texts, revealed as mercy (QS. Al Anbiya, 21:107), are often deployed as instruments of fear (Angiel, 2024; Smith, 2020). Ustaz quote verses like "Wa man yatawalla fa innallaha ghaniyyun" (QS. Al Mumtahanah, 60:4) to shame questioning students (Subhan, 2019) and cite hadiths like "Innama al a'malu binniyat" (HR. Bukhari No. 1) to accuse fatigued students of hypocrisy (Angiel, 2024). This proof texting transforms scripture into a weapon (Smith, 2020).

No previous study has examined this hermeneutical dimension of symbolic violence in pesantren (Subhan, 2019; Najib & Suryadi, 2021), though Western literature has documented similar scriptural abuse (Angiel, 2024; Smith, 2020). This study offers four contributions. It empirically documents weaponized scripture in pesantren (Austin, 1975; Bourdieu, 2014). It theorizes scriptural violence through theological gaslighting, eschatological blackmail, and prophetic proof texting (Angiel, 2024; Pargament, 2011). It identifies hermeneutical trauma

from a threatening divine image (Smith, 2020; Najib & Suryadi, 2021). And it offers trauma informed pedagogical reforms (Subhan, 2019; Hasyim, 2020).

METHODS

Research Site A Modern Pesantren in East Java

The study was conducted at Bumi Shalawat Islamic Boarding School, a pseudonym for SMA Progresif Bumi Shalawat, located in Sidoarjo, East Java. This institution was purposively selected because it represents a hybrid model. It combines traditional salaf pesantren elements like daily kitab kuning study, strict scheduling, dress codes, and communal prayers with modern schooling such as national curriculum, science laboratories, and computer classes. The school enrolls approximately three hundred Santri annually, with a student teacher ratio of fifteen to one. To protect privacy, specific identifiers like exact location, principal's name, and photographs are omitted.

However, key characteristics relevant to the study are as follows. There is a formalized hierarchy from mudir or director to ustaz to musyrif or mentor to senior Santri (Subhan, 2019). There is a written code of conduct with explicit punishments (Febriani & Anwar, 2022). There is a daily schedule from

four in the morning to ten at night with only two hours of free time. And there is a reputation among local communities as disciplined and religious (Hasyim, 2020).

Participant Selection and Characteristics

Table 1: Profile of Participants

Participant	Status	Years	Grade
R1	Current santri	2	11
R2	Current santri	3	12
R3	Alumnus	5	Graduated 2022
R4	Alumnus	3	Graduated 2023
R5	Alumnus	6	Graduated 2021

Five participants were recruited through purposive and snowball sampling. Inclusion criteria were being a current Santri or alumnus of Bumi Shalawat for at least two years, self reporting experiences of fear, anxiety, or pressure related to religious conformity, willingness to share sensitive experiences in depth, and age between

sixteen and twenty five years. Exclusion criteria included active psychotic disorders or ongoing legal cases involving the institution.

Data Collection

Data was collected in early 2025 over six weeks using three methods. First, semi structured interviews lasting sixty to ninety minutes each were audio recorded and transcribed verbatim. The interview guide included questions like "Describe a time you felt afraid of a teacher," "What happens when someone breaks a rule?", "Can you recall a time when an ustaz quoted the Qur'an or hadith to make you feel afraid or ashamed? What exact words did they use?", and "How do you feel when praying alone after leaving pesantren?"

Second, participant observation was conducted over three visits lasting four to six hours each. I observed morning assembly, tahajjud prayer which is optional but strongly encouraged, classroom teaching, and lunch breaks. Field notes were written within twenty four hours.

Third, document analysis was performed on the daily schedule, the written code of conduct which ran twelve pages, and an anonymized punishment log. Additionally, I analyzed classroom materials with permission and anonymized, including lesson plans for Hadith class, a list of daily

memorization verses, and a compilation of disciplinary quotes posted on the classroom wall. I also recorded, with consent, one forty five minute tafsir session, focusing on how the ustaz handled student questions.

Data Analysis

Analysis followed thematic analysis with a deductive inductive hybrid approach. Deductive codes derived from Bourdieu (2014), such as symbolic capital, habitus, doxa, symbolic violence, and misrecognition, and from Goffman (2021), such as front stage and back stage. Inductive codes emerged from the data, for example "fear of being seen as hypocrite" and "physical symptoms of anxiety." Coding was performed manually using NVivo 14. Inter coder reliability was checked by an independent researcher, yielding a kappa of 0.84. Member checking was conducted with three participants who confirmed the interpretation.

I also coded for scriptural violence specifically. I looked at quoted texts, including specific surah, verse number, and hadith collection. I examined hermeneutical moves like decontextualization, which means quoting only half a verse, transposition, which means applying a verse about disbelief to a student's fatigue, and absolutization, which means ignoring scholarly differences. I also coded for emotional outcomes such as

fear, shame, self doubt, anger, and avoidance (Smith, 2020; Pargament, 2011).

Ethical Considerations

Ethical approval was obtained from an institutional review board equivalent, namely SMA Progresif Bumi Shalawat Research Ethics Committee with approval number BS EC 2025 002. Informed consent included a clear explanation of the study's aim to examine trauma, the right to withdraw without penalty, confidentiality through pseudonyms for the school and participants and redaction of identifying details, and referral to a counseling psychologist if distress emerged. No participants required referral.

RESULT AND ANALYSES

This section presents the findings organized around the three mechanisms of scriptural violence identified in the data, plus additional themes about internalization and resistance (Subhan, 2019; Najib & Suryadi, 2021).

Theological Gaslighting Your Feelings Are from Satan

Theological gaslighting occurs when an ustaz denies a Santri's legitimate emotional or physical experience by attributing it to spiritual weakness or demonic influence, using scripture as evidence (Angiel, 2024; Pargament, 2011).

R2, a current female Santri aged nineteen, told me this story. "One night I was extremely tired after a full day of classes and extra lessons. I could not focus on tahajjud. My eyes kept closing. The musyrif reported me. The next morning, the ustaz called me in front of the class and recited 'Innamal 'isru yusrā' which is QS Al Insyirah verse 5, 'Indeed with hardship comes ease.' Then he said, 'Your tiredness is an excuse from shaytan. Allah promises ease after hardship, so if you feel hardship, it means your iman is weak. You are not trying.' I tried to explain, but he cut me off. 'Do not argue with Allah's word.'"

The ustaz decontextualized a verse about eschatological relief to dismiss a physical reality (Bourdieu, 2014; Subhan, 2019). The student's exhaustion was redefined as moral failure. This is theological gaslighting because it makes the student doubt her own bodily sensations (Pargament, 2011). Any objection becomes not just disagreement with the ustaz but disagreement with Allah (Austin, 1975).

R4, a twenty year old alumna, gave another example. "I once asked why we had to pray exactly at midnight for tahajjud, since the Prophet said the last third of the night is best, not exactly midnight. The ustaz's face turned red. He said '*La ta'kulu al suhufa'* or

'don't eat the papers' meaning you are not a scholar. Then he said the Prophet said '*Idza qultu syai'an fa khadzuha 'ala wajhihi'* which means 'When I say something, take it as it is.' I later learned that hadith is fabricated. Then he quoted QS An Nisa verse 59. 'O you who believe, obey Allah and obey the Messenger and those in authority among you.' He pointed at himself. 'I am your authority. Questioning me is like questioning the Prophet.' I never asked again."

This incident reveals prophetic proof texting, citing a verse about obeying ulil amri to equate the ustaz's arbitrary rule with divine command (Smith, 2020; Subhan, 2019). The student felt not only silenced but sinful for a legitimate pedagogical question (Angiel, 2024).

Eschatological Blackmail Allah Will Punish

Eschatological blackmail is the threat of divine punishment such as Hell or curse to enforce compliance with institutional rules, even those unrelated to core religious obligations (Smith, 2020; Pargament, 2011).

R5, a twenty five year old male alumnus who spent eight years in the pesantren, told me this. "The ustaz would say '*Man taraka al sunnah fa laysa minna'* or 'Whoever abandons the sunnah is not from us.' The actual hadith is about abandoning the

sunnah intentionally and permanently, but he applied it to trivial things like not wearing a kopyah, not saying bismillah loudly before eating, even laughing too loudly. Once I laughed with a friend after lights out. The ustaz came in and recited QS Al Hujurat verse 12. 'O you who believe, avoid much suspicion and do not spy.' Then he said, 'You are spying on each other's fun? Allah will curse those who make mischief in the night.' I cried that night. I thought Allah hated me for laughing."

The ustaz took a verse about backbiting and misapplied it to normal adolescent laughter (Angiel, 2024). The effect is to moralize every behavior, leaving no space for innocent human activity (Goffman, 2021). R5 internalized that Allah hated him for laughing. This is the core of religious trauma (Smith, 2020). The divine is transformed from merciful to punitive and capricious (Pargament, 2011).

R1, a seventeen year old male current Santri, said this. "If you forget to pray fajr on time because you overslept, the ustaz does not just wake you. He recites '*Fa wailun lil mushallin. Alladzina hum 'an shalatihim sahun*' which is QS Al Ma'un verses 4 and 5. 'So woe to those who pray, who are heedless of their prayer.' He says, 'You think you are better than those hypocrites?' I used to feel

guilty. Now I feel like I can never be good enough."

QS Al Ma'un refers to people who pray without compassion for orphans, not accidental oversleeping (Febriani & Anwar, 2022). The ustaz weaponized it to induce guilt over a minor mistake. This transforms every human imperfection into evidence of hypocrisy (Bourdieu, 2014), eroding the student's sense of being a worthy believer (Najib & Suryadi, 2021).

Prophetic Proof Texting Fabricated and Misapplied Hadiths

Perhaps the most disturbing finding is the use of fabricated or severely misapplied hadiths to legitimize abusive practices (Subhan, 2019). Islamic scholarship has a rich tradition of hadith criticism, but in Bumi Shalawat, ustaz often cited weak or false narrations without verification (Hasyim, 2020).

R3, a twenty two year old male alumnus, explained. "The ustaz used to say '*Adibuu awladakum 'ala thalathi 'ala taqwalah, wa 'ala thob'ih, wa 'ala khishyatihi*' which means 'Discipline your children in three things, taqwa, good character, and fear.' I later searched this hadith. It is not in any major collection. It is a saying of some tabi'in, but the ustaz presented it as the Prophet's words. He used

it to justify making us stand in the sun for hours. 'Fear,' he said, 'means physical punishment.'"

The ustaz committed hadith forgery by attribution, attributing a non prophetic saying to the Prophet (Angiel, 2024). This gives his sadistic pedagogy a fake prophetic mandate. The student cannot challenge it without seeming to challenge the Prophet (Smith, 2020).

R4 added this. "When any girl questioned the dress code, why hijab must be black, why socks must cover ankles, the female ustazah would say 'The Prophet cursed women who wear tight clothes. Did you know 'ma min imra'atin tadhabu fi thaurillah'? She quoted a hadith that says women who wear perfume and go to the mosque will have their prayers rejected. But our question was about socks, not perfume. It made no sense. But we could not argue."

This is analogical misapplication (Bourdieu, 2014; Foucault, 1977). The precise content of the text becomes irrelevant. Its performative function, silencing and shaming, is all that matters (Austin, 1975; Goffman, 2021).

The Internalization of a Threatening God

Through repeated exposure to scriptural violence, Santri develop a theological trauma schema where God is

perceived as punitive, monitoring, and easily angered. This schema persists long after leaving pesantren (Angiel, 2024; Pargament, 2011).

R5 said, "I cannot pray without hearing the ustaz's voice in my head, quoting verses about hellfire. Even when I recite Al Fatihah, I remember 'Ihdina al sirata al mustaqim' and I think, what if I am not on the straight path? What if I am one of those who earned anger? Now every small mistake in prayer makes me panic."

R2 told me, "I used to love listening to Qur'an recitation. Now when I hear certain verses, like 'Inna jahannama kanat mirshada' which means 'Indeed Hell has been lying in wait,' I feel nauseous. I know the verse is about disbelievers, but the ustaz used it for us. He made us memorize it while standing in the sun. Now the sound of that surah triggers my anxiety."

These accounts reveal conditioned aversion to sacred texts (Pargament, 2011; Smith, 2020). The Qur'an becomes a trauma trigger. This is the most severe form of religious trauma (Angiel, 2024). The sacred itself becomes profaned (Najib & Suryadi, 2021).

Hermeneutical Resistance and Its Costs

Despite the oppressive environment, some participants developed subtle forms of

resistance, but at great psychological cost (Goffman, 2021; Foucault, 1977).

R3, now an alumnus, studies hadith criticism online. "After leaving, I discovered that many hadiths our ustaz used are weak or fabricated. I felt betrayed. But also, I cannot forgive myself for believing him for so long. Why did I not question earlier?" This post traumatic shame adds a secondary layer of harm (Angiel, 2024; Pargament, 2011).

R4 said, "I started reading tafsir on my own after graduation. I found that QS Al Ma'un is about neglecting orphans, not oversleeping. I was angry for months. But I still cannot pray without anxiety. Knowing the truth intellectually does not heal the wounds."

R1, still in the pesantren, cannot resist openly. "I know some of the hadiths are probably weak. But if I say that, I will be accused of being a 'Qur'ani' or an apostate. So I just nod. Inside I am screaming."

This double consciousness, knowing the manipulation but being forced to perform belief, produces what I call *habitus in tension* (Bourdieu, 2014; Cooley, 2022), exacerbated by hermeneutical dissonance (Goffman, 2021; Subhan, 2019).

Observational Corroboration The Classroom as Courtroom

During my observation of a tafsir session on Surah Al Kahf, the ustaz presented a list of ten hadiths about the virtues of Friday. When a student hesitantly asked whether reading Surah Al Kahf on Friday guarantees forgiveness until next Friday, the ustaz snapped. "The Prophet said '*Man qara'a surah al kahfi yaum al jumu'ati adha'alahu min al nur ma bayn al jumu'atayn.*' Are you saying the Prophet lied?" The student apologized immediately. No discussion of hadith grading occurred. The classroom operated as a theological courtroom where questioning was punished by accusations of doubting the Prophet (Foucault, 1977; Bourdieu, 2014).

I also observed a wall poster in the dormitory hallway listing fifteen Qur'anic verses about punishment. The first was QS Al Baqarah verse 174 about those who conceal revealed scripture, with a hand drawn flame icon. No verses about mercy, forgiveness, or God's love were displayed anywhere. This visual imbalance reinforces a punitive theological schema (Smith, 2020; Pargament, 2011).

CONCLUSION

This study has demonstrated that pesantren teachers at Bumi Shalawat

systematically weaponize Qur'anic verses and hadiths as instruments of symbolic violence, producing profound religious trauma among Santri (Subhan, 2019; Najib & Suryadi, 2021). Three mechanisms were identified. Theological gaslighting denies a student's embodied reality by redefining exhaustion or doubt as spiritual weakness (Angiel, 2024; Pargament, 2011). Eschatological blackmail threatens divine punishment for minor infractions such as laughing or oversleeping, transforming normal adolescent behavior into sin (Smith, 2020). Prophetic proof texting uses fabricated or misapplied hadiths to legitimize abusive pedagogy (Subhan, 2019).

The result is a theological trauma schema where God is perceived as punitive, monitoring, and easily angered. This schema persists long after leaving pesantren, leading to long term spiritual avoidance, prayer related anxiety, conditioned aversion to sacred texts, and a fractured relationship with the divine (Pargament, 2011; Smith, 2020; Angiel, 2024). Participants reported panic during prayer, nausea when hearing certain Qur'anic verses, difficulty wearing hijab, and even loss of basic religious practice such as fajr prayer.

Beyond individual suffering, this study reveals a systemic problem. The hierarchical

authority structure of pesantren, combined with the absence of hermeneutical accountability, allows scripture to be selectively quoted and decontextualized without consequence (Bourdieu, 2014; Foucault, 1977). Santri are silenced not by physical force but by the internalized fear that questioning an ustaz means questioning Allah (Goffman, 2021; Cooley, 2022).

Recommendations

Based on the voices of participants and theoretical analysis, this study offers several recommendations.

For pesantren, five actions are urgent. First, ban public scriptural shaming. No student should be humiliated using a Qur'anic verse or hadith. Second, establish a hadith verification committee to ensure that only authentic narrations are used for discipline. Third, train ustaz in contextual hermeneutics through workshops on tafsir methodology, occasions of revelation or asbab al nuzul, and abrogation or nasikh mansukh. Fourth, introduce a mercy curriculum, weekly sessions focused solely on verses about God's love, forgiveness, and compassion. Fifth, create confidential complaint channels so students can report abuse of scripture without fear of retaliation (Hasyim, 2020; Febriani & Anwar, 2022; Subhan, 2019).

For policymakers at the Ministry of Religious Affairs, develop national guidelines for the ethical use of scripture in pesantren pedagogy, with clear sanctions for verified scriptural abuse (Hasyim, 2020).

For researchers, conduct larger scale studies across multiple pesantren types, including surveys on the prevalence of scriptural violence and longitudinal studies on the long term effects of religious trauma (Najib & Suryadi, 2021; Smith, 2020).

Concluding Reflection

The Qur'an opens with "*Bismillahirrahmanirrahim*" meaning "In the name of Allah, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful." Any pedagogy that uses these same words to terrorize children is not just educationally unsound. It is theologically corrupt (Angiel, 2024; Pargament, 2011). Pesantren must return to the prophetic "*rahmatan lil 'alamin*" ethos, where scripture heals rather than wounds, liberates rather than enslaves (Hasyim, 2020). This study has given voice to five Santri who suffered the latter. It is time for the institution to listen, to repent, and to reform (Subhan, 2019; Smith, 2020).

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